

As the US investigates German drug prices, here's why Europe should care

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【要点】

- ・ 米国はドイツの医薬品価格設定制度が不公正な貿易慣行であるかどうかについて調査を開始し、同意しない場合は関税を含む通商措置の実施を検討している。
- ・ ドイツはこの調査に対して、米国企業への差別はなく、システムは確立され均衡が取れていると反論している。
- ・ 米国がドイツに対して不公正な貿易慣行を認定した場合、医薬品部門に限らず自動車産業などの他部門にも関税が適用される可能性がある。
- ・ ドイツの米国向け主要輸出品は自動車（285億ユーロ）と医薬品（280億ユーロ）であり、自動車産業が報復関税の主要ターゲットになる可能性が高い。
- ・ これらの関税は米国とEUの合意した15%の上限を超える可能性があり、ドイツを含むEU全体に広範な経済的影響を与える懸念がある。

【メール原文】

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By Helen Collis · Sep 21, 2026, 5:00 AM · [View in your browser](#)

Germany's drug-pricing system is about to face scrutiny in Washington. But the consequences could extend well beyond pharmaceuticals, with Germany's car industry potentially in the firing line too.

President Donald Trump has long targeted the high cost of medicines for American patients and put in place measures to drive prices down. Now, his administration is turning its attention to Europe.

"For too long, European countries have been freeloading off American innovation while our own patients and companies foot the bill," Vern Buchanan (R-Fla.), vice chair of the House Ways and Means Committee and chair of its health subcommittee, told POLITICO. "Europe needs to start paying its fair share."

The Trump administration is pressing EU countries to spend more on new drugs — or face trade measures such as tariffs. Because the EU trades as a bloc, that pressure could hit sectors across Europe.

Germany is the first EU country to come under this pressure.

On Tuesday, U.S. trade officials will launch a hearing into whether Germany's system for setting prices for new medicines amounts to an unfair trade practice.

Germany has rejected that suspicion. “There is no discrimination against U.S. companies,” a Health Ministry spokesperson told POLITICO. The system is “established and balanced” to ensure access to innovation and sustainable supply, the spokesperson added: “We stand behind this system.”

If Washington rules against Berlin, the fallout may not be confined to German drugmakers.

“There’s nothing that requires that if there’s a finding of an unfair trade practice under [Section] 301, you only impose tariffs in that sector,” said Dan Mullaney, a former assistant U.S. Trade Representative and chief negotiator for trade agreements with the EU and U.K.

The U.S. could “easily” target other products with tariffs, said Mullaney, now a nonresident senior fellow at the Atlantic Council think tank’s Europe Center and GeoEconomics Center. “You’d select products based on what’s likely to influence Germany. Automotive would be the obvious one.”

Mullaney also said tariffs could fall outside an agreed 15% ceiling between the U.S. and EU. “It’s a separate unfair trade investigation that can go beyond the agreed horizontal tariffs,” he added.

Germany’s top export to the U.S. in 2025 was autos, trade figures show. It sold €28.5 billion worth of motor vehicles and parts to America, followed closely by pharmaceutical products at €28 billion.

A U.S. pharma lobbyist, granted anonymity due to the sensitive nature of ongoing discussions, said “the tariffs don’t necessarily need to be on pharmaceuticals,” adding: “It’s really about the leverage the United States government believes it would have to compel the other party to change those practices or to arrive at some agreement.”

What the U.S. wants

Washington wants a drug pricing deal with Berlin similar to the one it agreed with London, to spend more on innovative medicines.

The Office of the United States Trade Representative accuses Germany — and the rest of the EU — of benefiting from Washington’s higher drug prices, which it says finance the costly research needed to develop new drugs.

While Berlin rejects these claims, there have been back channel-talks with Washington for months. Officials from Germany’s health and economic affairs ministries are exploring a proposal that they could put to Washington to stave off the threat of tariffs.

Politicians in Berlin, however, consider it highly unlikely Germany would agree to big price increases.

“We will not allow foreign governments to dictate how we set medicine prices in Germany,” Matthias Mieves, a lawmaker with the governing Social Democrats who is leading work to develop health industry policy, told POLITICO.

“The problem is not that prices in Germany are too low. We pay good, high prices. The reality is that drug prices in the United States are far too high,” he said.

Washington takes a different view. It has its own laundry list of changes it wants Germany to make to avoid a finding of unfair trade practices.

The U.S. pharma lobbyist cited above laid out three broad demands: Germany should increase the share of its GDP spending on innovative medicines; roll back recent changes to further discount prices of new medicines; and introduce a compliance mechanism to make sure any commitments to Washington are implemented.

Germany spends less than half as much as the U.S. on new drugs as a share of GDP, the lobbyist said.

Berlin passed a law in July to lower drug prices as part of sweeping reforms to address a projected €18 billion deficit in the health system next year.

In response, companies like Eli Lilly and Boehringer Ingelheim announced investment cuts or withdrawals in Germany.

What to expect

The USTR is required by law to hold a public hearing as part of the Section 301 process. While the session is unlikely to reveal Washington's negotiating position, who testifies and what arguments they make will offer a useful window on where both sides stand.

Berlin is not sending a representative to plead its case. Instead, a German embassy representative in Washington will "participate as an observer," the health ministry said.

Foreign governments sometimes opt to testify at these hearings to publicly make their case, but are not required to. Some prefer private talks with U.S. officials — as the German government is doing.

The U.S. officials, usually career staff, typically ask technical or clarifying questions and don't use the hearings for political grandstanding.

The German Chamber of Industry and Commerce, which gave a written statement at an earlier stage in the investigation, will also not attend.

German medtech company Carl Zeiss, which also submitted a written statement earlier in the investigation, declined to comment, but said it "monitors developments in trade policy."

As of Friday afternoon, 10 speakers had requested permission to participate. Most are aligned with the Trump administration's position.

But the pressure on Germany is unlikely to disappear with the hearing.

"If you have a 301 investigation and that triggers these negotiations, you have to assume that they're serious," said Mullaney. "That if you don't get some kind of an outcome, that there will be some tariff rebalancing."

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